INTRODUCTION

The essays contained in this volume were written over half a decade, though most appeared between 2016 and 2018. Although penned separately, collectively they paint a portrait of geopolitics in the Indo-Pacific region, impressionistic in some cases and far from comprehensive to be sure, but a broad-based view nonetheless of how the region is changing, how it is not, and what are the key trends shaping Asia. Having spent much of the period from 2010 to 2017 focused on researching and writing my book *The End of the Asian Century* and penning regular columns for the *Wall Street Journal*, as well as publishing numerous opinion pieces for *National Review*, *Politico*, *The Atlantic*, and other outlets, the occasional opportunity to strike a middle ground between writing a monograph and an op-ed became increasingly attractive. Being able to tackle more speculative ideas or interpretations of what I was seeing on my travels seemed, as well, a welcome alternative to the more direct policy pieces I was writing.

The following essays, most of them expanded and updated from their original form, deal with individual nations, including China, Japan, India, and North Korea; bilateral relations between Japan and China; and American strategy in the Indo-Pacific. The collection starts out with an argument to bring back the idea of the "Asiatic Mediterranean,"